

INDEPENDENT STUDY FORM

What is an Independent Study?

An Independent Study is designed for students to further explore specific topics of interest with Sloan faculty members in a customized way and not specifically covered in a cataloged course.

Acceptable Projects	Unacceptable Projects
➤ Group projects – if same units/course # ➤ New academic learning ➤ Startups – if academic in nature ➤ 15.960 and 15.961 in same semester – if completely different topics	➤ Building on past projects ➤ Work for Conferences ➤ Extension of catalogued course or prior independent study ➤ Work/employment, paid or unpaid, with external company ➤ Same independent course # (15.960 or 15.961) repeated in same semester

What is the first step to start the Independent Study process?

Formulate a proposal and engage a faculty member willing to serve as your Faculty advisor; the [Sloan Faculty Expertise Guide](#) is a great resource. Then, you and your Faculty advisor will work out a plan of implementation, supervision, and evaluation of the final deliverable.

What is the difference between the two course numbers, 15.960 and 15.961?

The only difference between the course numbers is the fact that 15.960 is a P/D/F graded course and 15.961 is a letter graded course. The letter graded course will affect your GPA.

How do I Register for an Independent Study?

Step 1: Complete the independent study form and proposal, signed by you and the Faculty advisor, then submit to Christina Beck (cbeck@mit.edu).

Step 2: After documents are submitted, register for 15.960 (P/D/F Grading) or 15.961 (Letter Grading) for the correct number of units listed on your proposal via the online add/drop form on WebSIS.

Step 3: Once approved, log back into the online add/drop form and click “Submit to Registrar” to commit the change to your registration.

*Your Independent study will only be approved via the online add/drop form on WebSIS in concurrence with Step 1 *

Registration Deadlines:

➤ **Fall – Wednesday, November 19, 2025**

➤ **IAP – Thur., January 15, 2026**

➤ **Spring – Tues. April 21, 2026**

Note: All deadlines are at 12:00 pm.

My online add/drop form hasn’t been approved yet – what else do I need to do?

Your Independent study will be only be approved via the online add/drop form on WebSIS in concurrence with completion of this form and attached proposal. The online add/drop form must also be completed before the Registration Deadline in order to avoid the petition process, which includes a \$50 fee. For dates, see the [MIT Academic Calendar](#).

INDEPENDENT STUDY FORM

ALL FIELDS REQUIRED:

Student Name: _____ Student Email Address: _____

Student ID#: _____ Sloan Faculty Advisor: _____

Term: ☐ Fall 2025 ☐ IAP 2026 ☐ Spring 2026

Course Registration: ☐ 15.960 - P/D/F grading ☐ 15.961 - Letter grading

Units: ☐ 6 = 40-50 hrs/term of work, full term (comparable to 6 unit elective)
☐ 9 = 85-95 hrs/term of work, full term (comparable to 9 unit elective)
☐ 12 = 140-150 hrs/term of work, full term (comparable to 12 unit elective)
☐ other: _____

NOTE: Any project that requires more than 12 units qualifies as a Thesis and undergoes a separate process. SES does not recommend Independent Studies under 3 units.

Project Completion Date (*due no later than the last day of scheduled classes*):

☐ **Wednesday, December 10** for Fall 2025 term ☐ **Wednesday, January 21** for IAP 2026

☒ **Tuesday, May 12** for Spring 2026



Student Signature

Date

Faculty Advisor Signature

Date

Note: Your Independent study will be approved via the online add/drop form on WebSIS with completion of this form and the following proposal template, submitted via email to Christina Beck (cbeck@mit.edu). For Questions, please contact Christina Beck in Educational Services.

INDEPENDENT STUDY PROPOSAL TEMPLATE

Instructions: Complete the following 4 questions in a 1-2 page proposal of your project. Find this 'Proposal Template' and additional materials on the **15.960** or **15.961** Canvas sites. You must submit the independent study form and proposal for the online add/drop form to be approved via WebSIS.

1. OVERVIEW

Summary or purpose of the study

- Description of the final deliverable (i.e. paper, project, business plan, etc.)

2. OBJECTIVE/GOALS

Schedule/Analysis Deadlines

- Outline of topics to be studied (i.e. behavioral and communication norms, technologies in use, entrepreneurial activities in organizations, etc.)
- Proposed Solution and Opportunities

3. QUESTIONS

Methodology and Next Steps

- How often will faculty meet with the student to assess progress, advances, and roadblocks?
- How often/in what format will faculty provide feedback?

4. POTENTIAL DATA SOURCES